deeply skewed in Pakistan's favour—something that India did not view to be in its strategic interest. But it was the changing international political environment towards Afghanistan that played a critical role in the rise of the partisans in 1996. Unlike what most Indian commentators argue, the shift in India's position occurred not simply because of the Taliban's militant Islamic practices or their dependence on Pakistan's security agencies (these aspects categorised the Mujahideen as well) but due to the breakdown of the international consensus on Afghanistan in the mid-1990s, as the UN failed to reconcile the warring factions. Only three countries, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates, recognised the Taliban as Afghanistan's official government. Instead of accepting its rise, regional powers such as Russia and Iran felt threatened by the Taliban and decided to contain its rise (militarily if required). It was this change in regional geopolitical equations that allowed the partisans in New Delhi to ally with Moscow and Tehran, and these three countries threw their weight behind the anti-Taliban United Front. They criticised others countries such as the US and China, which had functioning back channels with the Taliban, for abetting the latter's rise.

Though the breakdown of international consensus offered an opportunity for the partisans in India to initiate a policy change in 1996, it was the risk of losing allies in Moscow and Teheran that sealed the defeat of the conciliators. By 1996, both Russia and Iran had come to support India's case on Kashmir at the UN. Reaching out to the Taliban would have cost India this support as well as the connection to the United Front within Afghanistan. The only thing New Delhi could achieve by opening such communication was the 'possibility' of winning 'some' Taliban figures over. This policy dilemma was reconciled to some extent during the presidency of Hamid Karzai after 2001. With the international community's support, Karzai expanded relations with India and launched a reconciliation drive with cerain Taliban figures that were disillusioned by Pakistan. But until the events of 9/11 took place, India's Afghanistan policy remained in a state of flux. However, before Karzai's rise, what was the state of India's relations with US and Pakistan? The next chapter details how India's relations with the US and Pakistan, the destruction of the Bamiyan Buddhas, and